

people, how many made a claim, then how many went on to complain. This number should be low in the policy you finally choose.

Yup, you need a degree in finance, law and patience to choose a mediclaim policy. You could just look at the Mint SecureNow Medical Ratings if you find this process too complicated. Your exact policy type or need may not be in the ratings, but if you look at the parameters, you will get this data for the company. Who said choosing a medical policy is easy?

What to do if you are not getting cover because of a pre-existing disease?

A colleague wrote to me some time back. He had an angioplasty twelve years ago, but finds it difficult to get a cover even after a disease-free period of more than twelve years. Insurance companies ideally want to insure supermen and superwomen who are in the best of health and won't ever make a claim. Some companies take their aversion to giving cover to people with a pre-existing ailment to ridiculous lengths. If you fall in this category and are not getting cover, there are still some things you can do.

You can buy a policy with sub-limits, co-pay and an exclusion period for your existing ailment. Remember sub-limits are limits on what the policy will pay for certain diseases and for the room rent and related costs. A co-pay is what you agree to share with the company in terms of cost. An exclusion period is the waiting period before the policy will start paying a claim.

These are restrictive, but better than not having a policy. Also, you may get 'loaded' or pay an amount over the regular premium paid by a healthy person due to your pre-existing ailment.

What I suggested to my colleague is this: If you are totally unable to get a policy, start a regular systematic investment in a long-term product like a balanced mutual fund (we'll discuss this in more detail in [Chapter 9](#)) and mentally label it 'medical-cost fund'. If you were planning to buy a Rs 5-lakh cover, target a Rs 10-lakh fund for your medical costs. If you don't need the fund and stay healthy, this is money that you will bequeath to your kids.